From Learning to Care

A cultural gathering core at Tree Hollow

QianlongSun

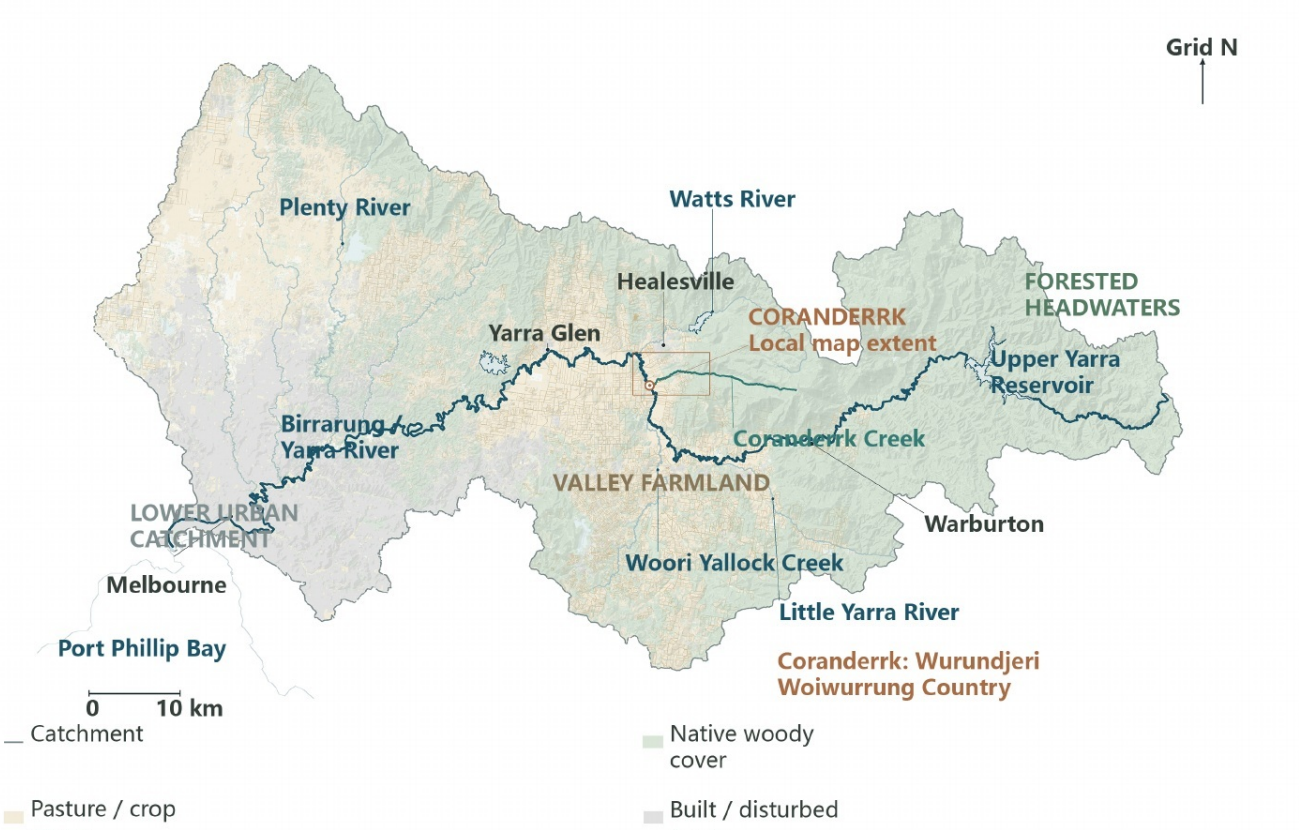
Project statement

Midway along the visitor route, Tree Hollow is the cultural gathering and learning core at Coranderrk, set among mature trees and existing woodland clearings.
The loop connects four experiences: eel-smoking and food learning, Seven Seasons gatherings, garden exploration and observation of hollow habitats. Seasonal changes can be observed in the planting, paving patterns and shifting shade. Visitors can pause at rest areas beside the woodland paths. The hollow and the surrounding ground remain undisturbed and will not be modified.
Visitors start at Station and can continue to Billabong and Camp. Reused materials and replaceable parts make maintenance easier. Guided visits, seed sales and farm surplus could help fund ongoing care. Site managers and Wurundjeri Knowledge Holders would guide the cultural interpretation at the site. Within the centre, visitors can also learn independently from the planting and signs.

01 / Read Country

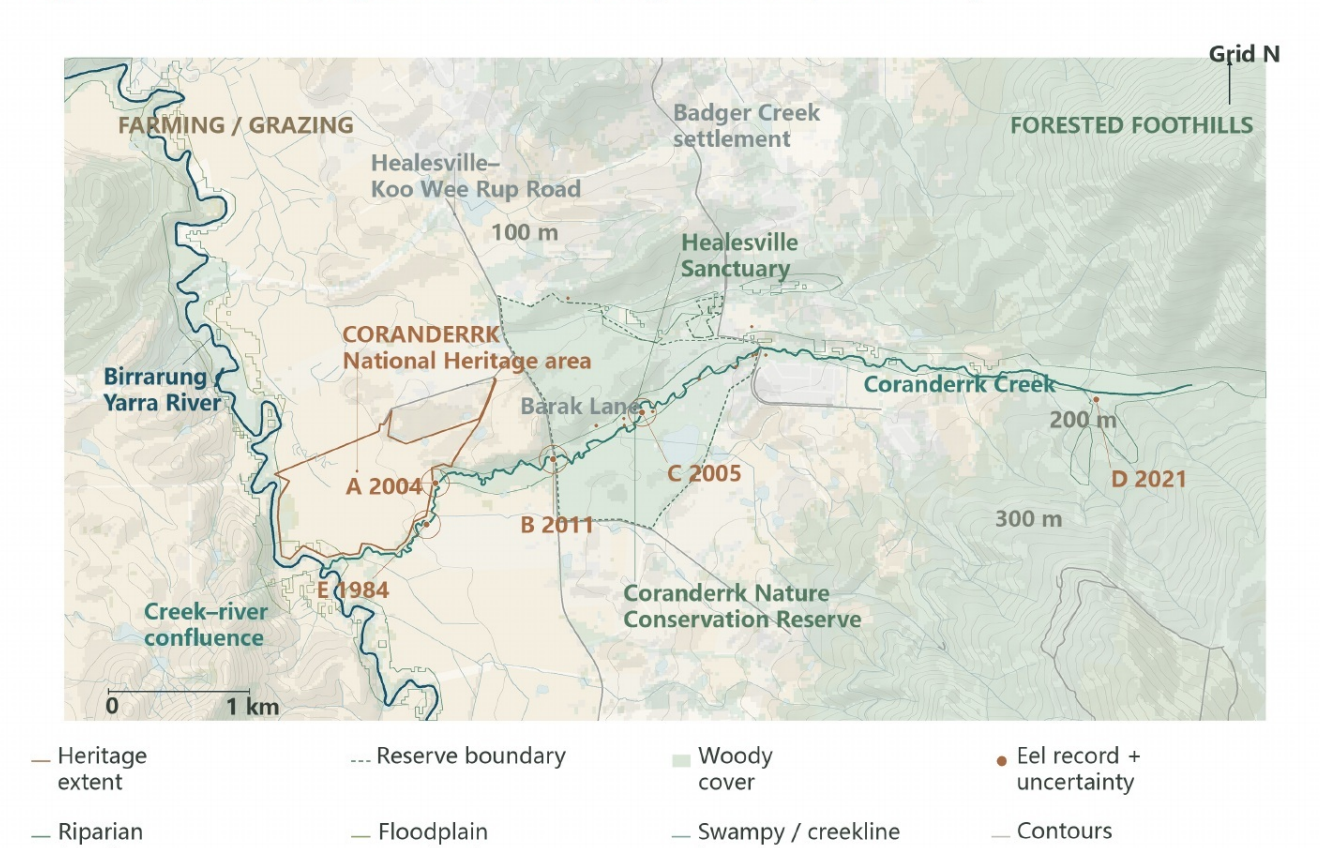
01.1 / Water, land and cultural connections

Coranderrk within the Birrarung catchment

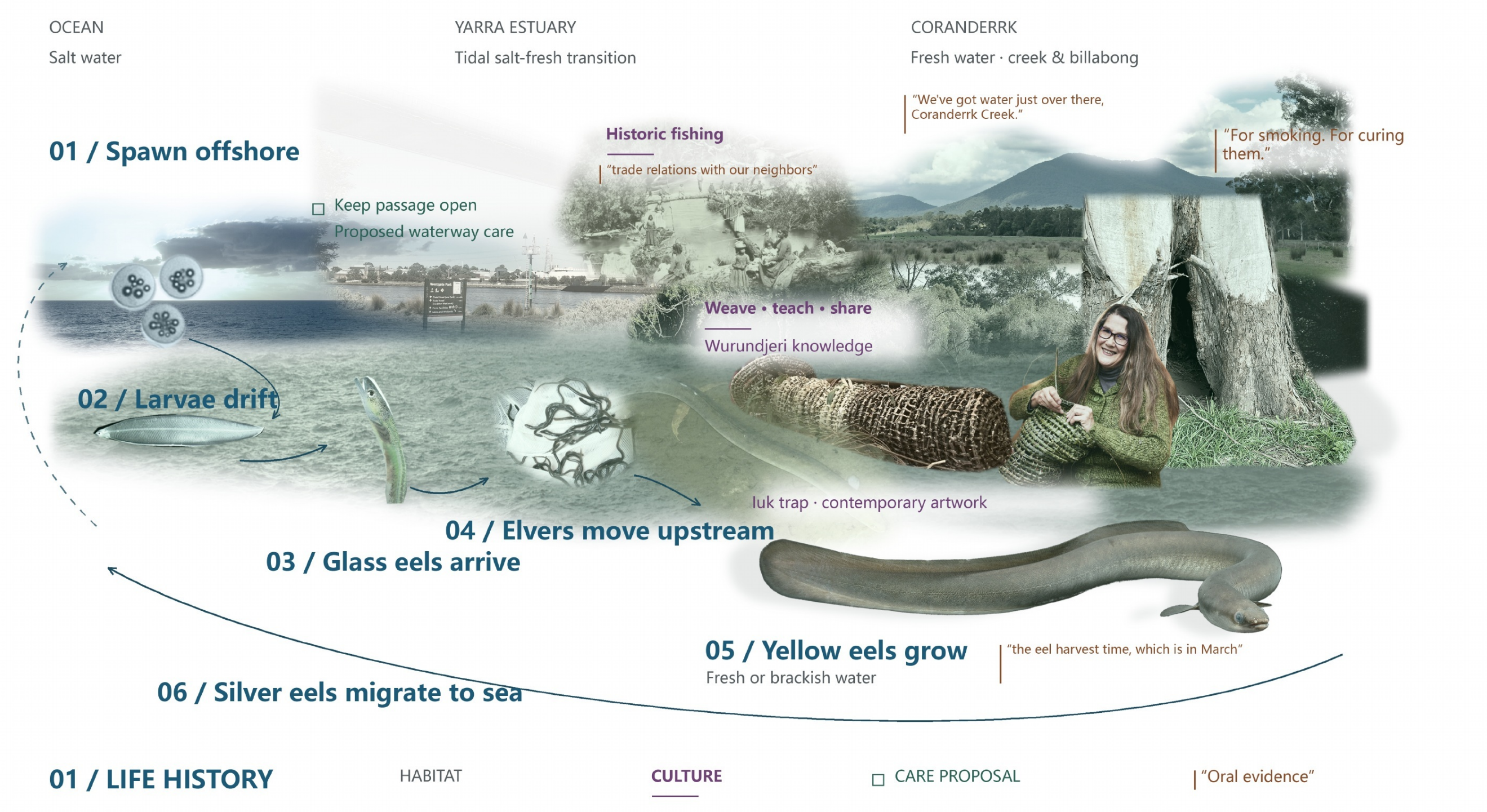


Coranderrk: water, vegetation and historical eel records

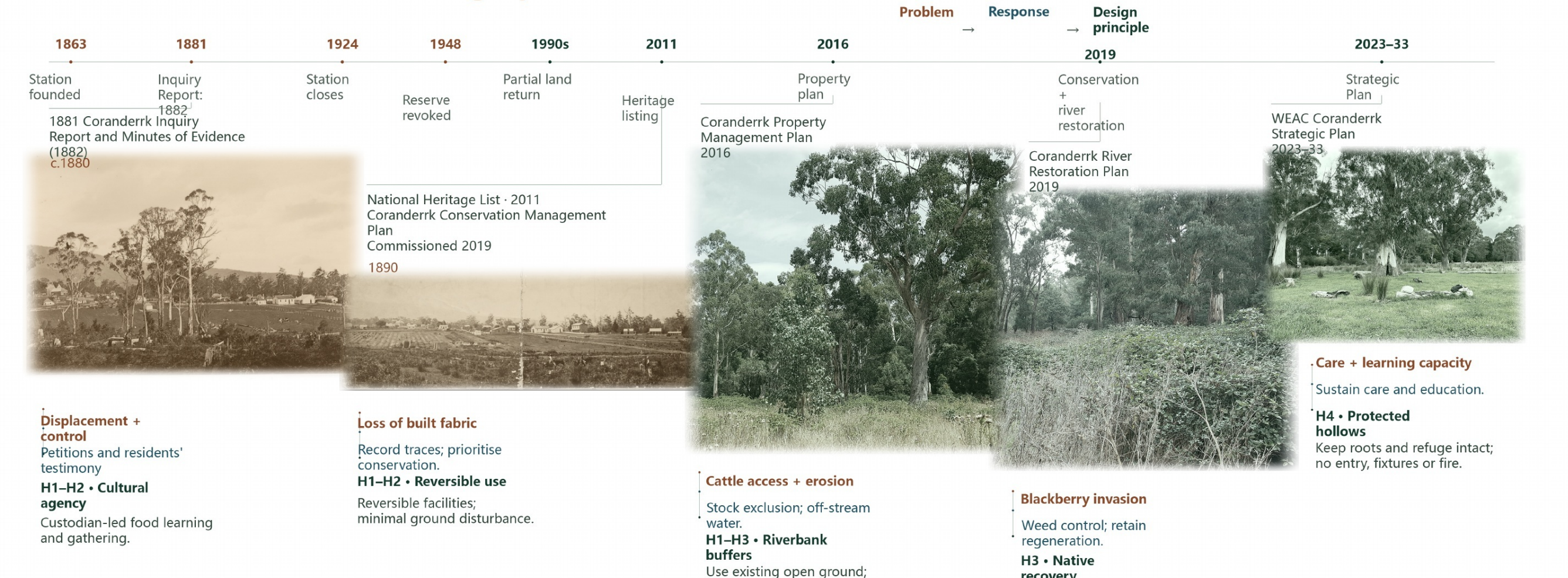
Mapped landscape context | Anguilla australis records | Design locations require field survey



01.2 / Eels, food and knowledge


OCEAN
Salt water
YARRA ESTUARY
Tidal salt-fresh transition
CORANDERRK
Fresh water · creek & billabong
"We've got water just over there, Coranderrk Creek."
01 / Spawn offshore
Historic fishing
"trade relations with our neighbors"
"For smoking. For curing them."
Keep passage open
Proposed waterway care
Weave • teach • share
Wurundjeri knowledge
02 / Larvae drift
luk trap · contemporary artwork
04 / Elvers move upstream
03 / Glass eels arrive
05 / Yellow eels grow
Fresh or brackish water
"the eel harvest time, which is in March"
06 / Silver eels migrate to sea
01 / LIFE HISTORY
HABITAT
CULTURE
CARE PROPOSAL
"Oral evidence"

01.3 / Restoration informs design priorities


Problem → Response → Design principle
1863 Station founded
1881 Inquiry Report: 1882
1881 Coranderrk Inquiry Report and Minutes of Evidence (1882)
c.1880
1924 Station closes
1948 Reserve revoked
1990s Partial land return
2011 Heritage listing
National Heritage List · 2011
Coranderrk Conservation Management Plan
Commissioned 2019
1890
2016 Property plan
Coranderrk Property Management Plan 2016
2019 Conservation + river restoration
Coranderrk River Restoration Plan 2019
2023–33 Strategic Plan
WEAC Coranderrk Strategic Plan 2023–33

Displacement + control
Petitions and residents' testimony
H1–H2 • Cultural agency
Custodian-led food learning and gathering.

Loss of built fabric
Record traces; prioritise conservation.
H1–H2 • Reversible use
Reversible facilities; minimal ground disturbance.

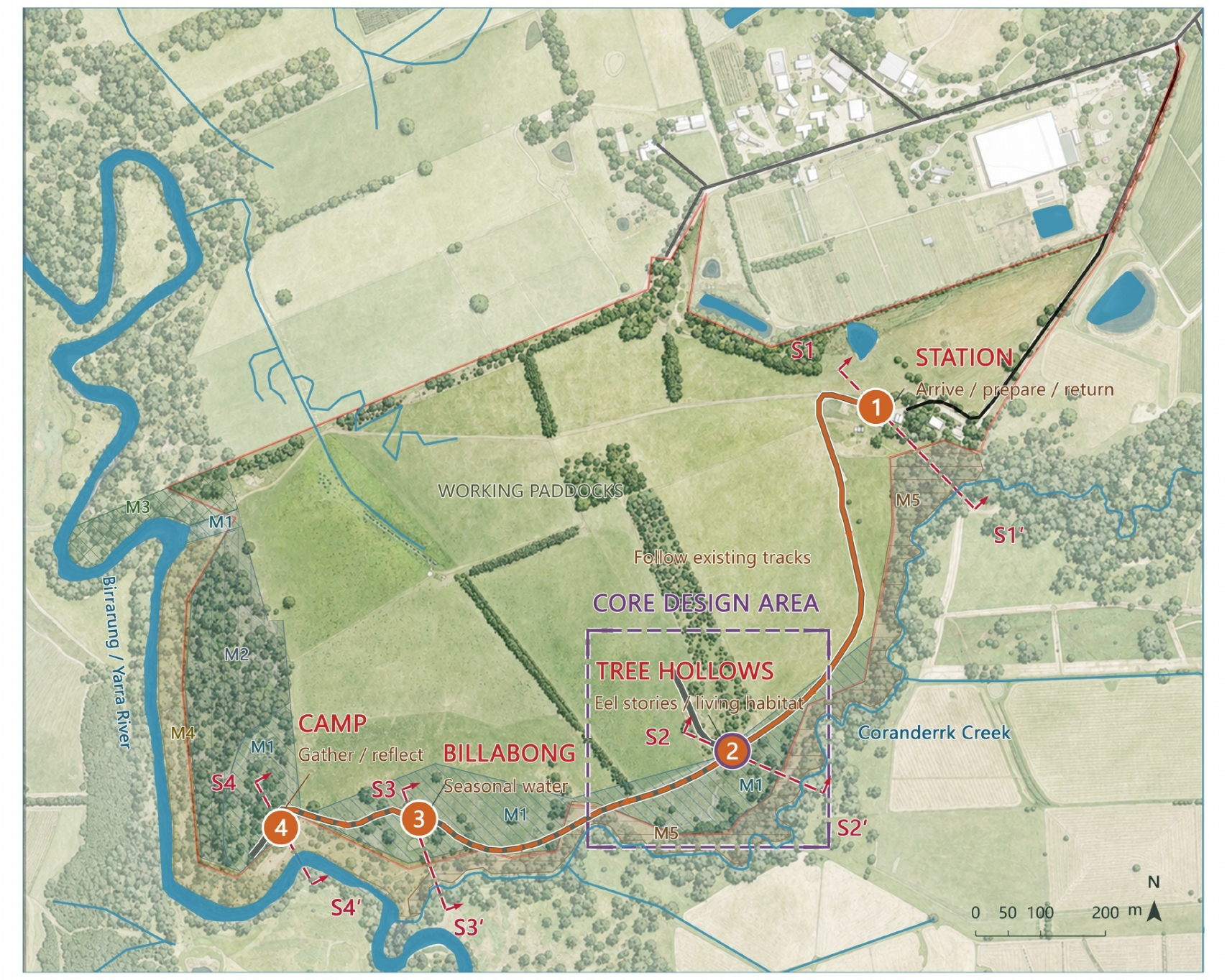
Cattle access + erosion
Stock exclusion; off-stream water.
H1–H3 • Riverbank buffers
Use existing open ground; set activity back from banks.

Blackberry invasion
Weed control; retain regeneration.
H3 • Native recovery
Observe from existing paths; avoid new clearing.

Care + learning capacity
Sustain care and education.
H4 • Protected hollows
Keep roots and refuge intact; no entry, fixtures or fire.

02 / Why Tree Hollow?

02.1 / Four nodes, one learning route



READING THE PLAN

- Visitor sequence on existing tracks
- Conditional continuation
- Core design area
- Section cut / viewing direction
- Waterways
- Site boundary

1 Prepare > 2 Eel stories > 3 Water cycles > 4 Gather
Return to Station via the same track network.
N3-N4 access responds to seasonal conditions.

Restoration management / 2019 plan

- M1 Weed control + revegetation
- M2 Weed control + revegetation
- M3 Weed control, fencing + planting
- M4 Weed control
- M5 Weed control inside riparian fence

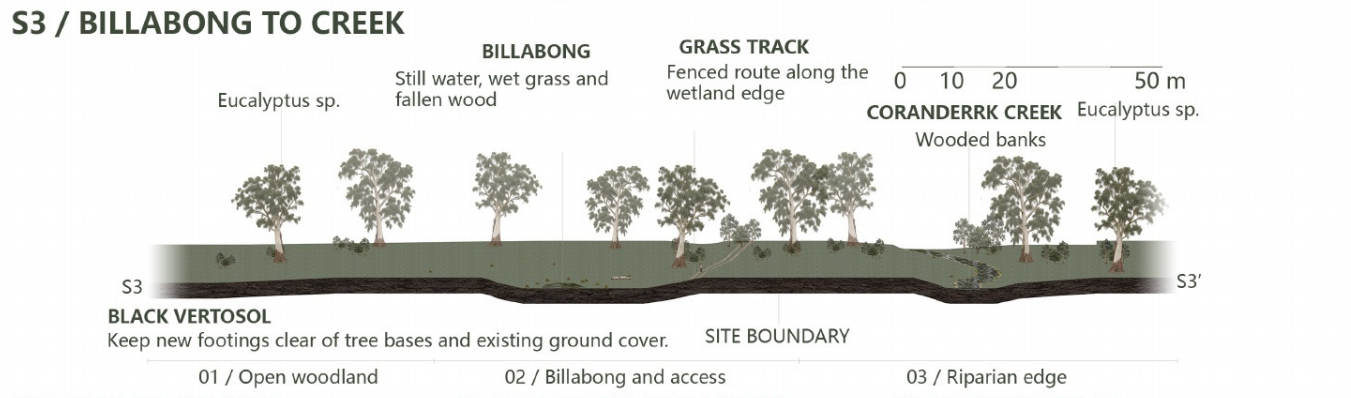
02.2 / Field evidence for choosing N2

Hollow + woodland edge + existing route

Habitat learning + cultural gathering

02.3 / Site sections guide the design

S3 / BILLABONG TO CREEK


Eucalyptus sp.
BILLABONG
Still water, wet grass and fallen wood
GRASS TRACK
Fenced route along the wetland edge
CORANDERRK CREEK
Wooded banks
0 10 20 50 m
S3
S3'
BLACK VERTOSOL
Keep new footings clear of tree bases and existing ground cover.
SITE BOUNDARY

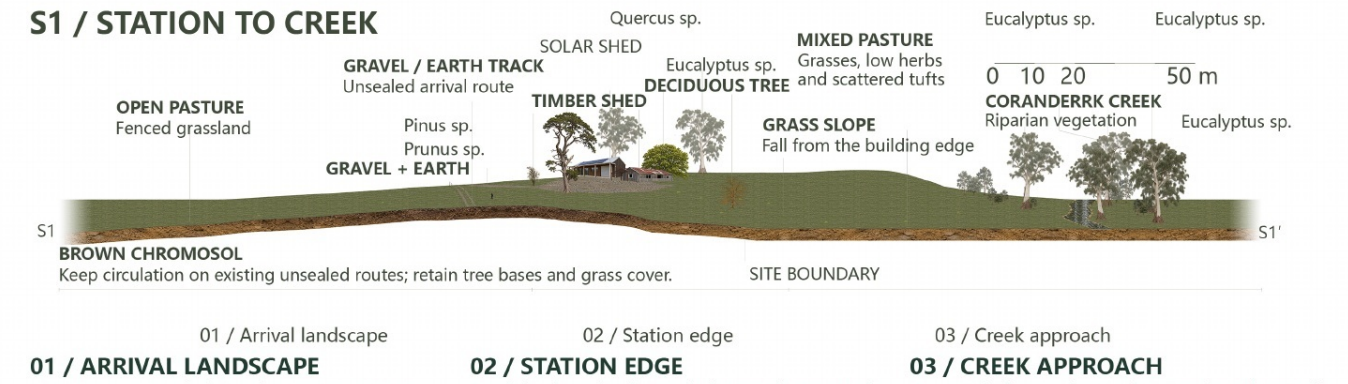
01 / OPEN WOODLAND
Open ground leads to the wetland, framed by mature tree groups.
Retain the open approach, tree groups, fallen wood and undisturbed tree bases.

02 / BILLABONG AND ACCESS
The track follows a wetland mosaic of water, low vegetation and fallen wood.
Observe from the existing track; keep gathering and fixtures off the wet bank.

03 / RIPARIAN EDGE
Dense bank vegetation separates the open ground from the creek.
Retain bank vegetation; use authorised records at N1 or N2 when access is closed.

SITE ANALYSIS — DESIGN RESPONSE

S1 / STATION TO CREEK

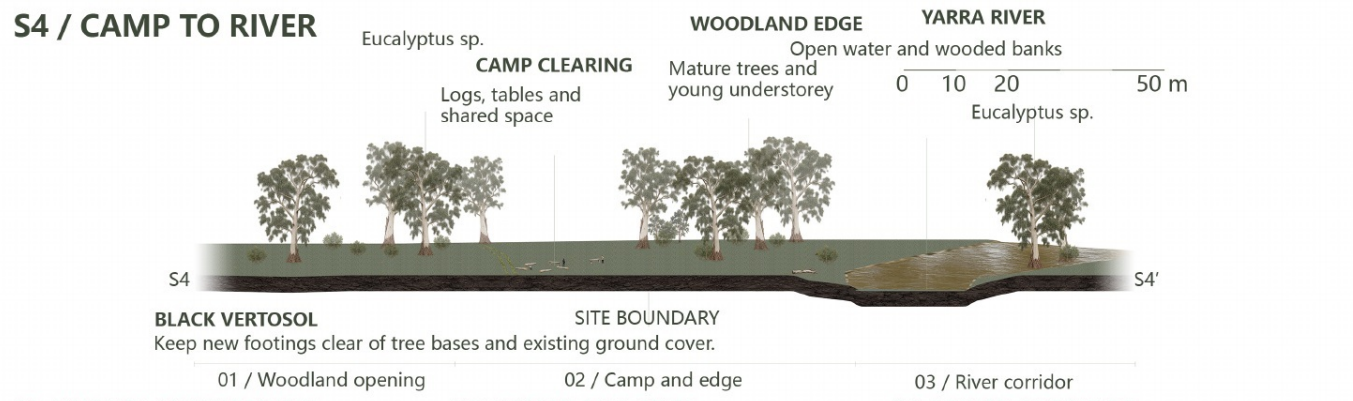


01 / ARRIVAL LANDSCAPE
Uneven, unsealed tracks carry access through pasture.
Follow the existing route; check continuous access before placing furniture.

02 / STATION EDGE
Beside the sheds and slope, the gravel yard provides shade and level working space.
Use the yard for preparation and return; keep slope edges and tree bases clear.

03 / CREEK APPROACH
Ground slopes from the station through pasture to the wooded creek.
Observe from the existing route; retain ground cover and creek-edge vegetation.

S4 / CAMP TO RIVER

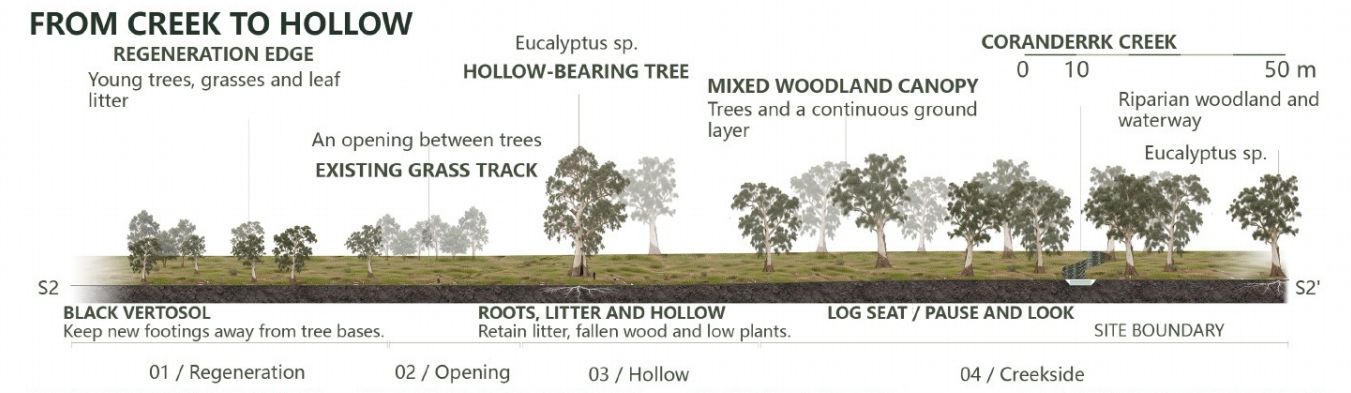

Eucalyptus sp.
CAMP CLEARING
Logs, tables and shared space
WOODLAND EDGE
Mature trees and young understorey
YARRA RIVER
Open water and wooded banks
0 10 20 50 m
S4
S4'
BLACK VERTOSOL
Keep new footings clear of tree bases and existing ground cover.
SITE BOUNDARY

01 / WOODLAND OPENING
Tree spacing allows access; ground vegetation connects the woodland edges.
Use the existing opening; retain litter, fallen wood and young growth.

02 / CAMP AND EDGE
Shared activities occupy a clearing beside dense understorey.
Keep shared activities within the existing clearing; limit new fixtures.

03 / RIVER CORRIDOR
The river extends views beyond the clearing into the wider landscape.
Orient shared views towards the river; keep activities back from vegetated banks.

FROM CREEK TO HOLLOW


REGENERATION EDGE
Young trees, grasses and leaf litter
HOLLOW-BEARING TREE
Eucalyptus sp.
An opening between trees
EXISTING GRASS TRACK
MIXED WOODLAND CANOPY
Trees and a continuous ground layer
CORANDERRK CREEK
Riparian woodland and waterway
0 10 50 m
S2
S2'
BLACK VERTOSOL
Keep new footings away from tree bases.
ROOTS, LITTER AND HOLLOW
Retain litter, fallen wood and low plants.
LOG SEAT / PAUSE AND LOOK
SITE BOUNDARY

01 / REGENERATION EDGE
Low canopy and open ground reveal seasonal change from the path.
H3 / Observe from the existing route; retain young trees and low vegetation.

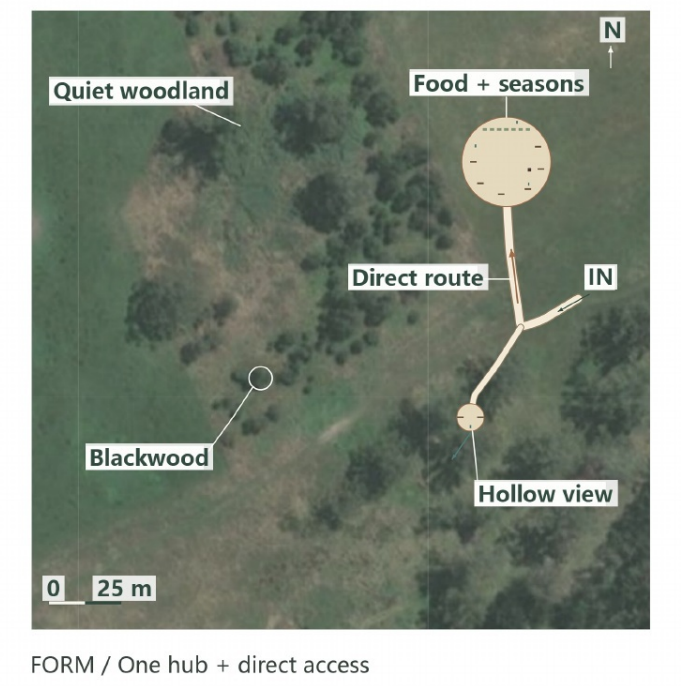
02 / PATH AND OPENING
The track edge accommodates both movement and pausing between trees.
H1 + H2 / Place gathering and food learning beside the route; keep a clear passage.

03 / HOLLOW AND GROUND
Roots, litter and low vegetation connect the hollow to a wider habitat.
H2 + H4 / Face seating towards the tree; keep fixtures clear of its base and retain ground habitat.

04 / RIPARIAN WOODLAND
Tree cover connects the hollow' s habitat to the waterway.
H4 / Retain creekside canopy; keep group activities away from the bank and habitat floor.

02.4 / Comparison of two alternative schemes

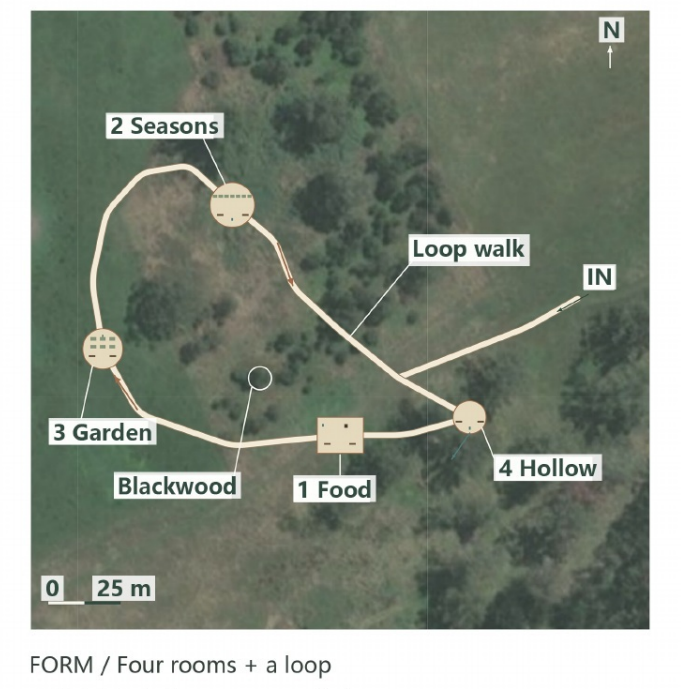
A / SINGLE COMMONS



FORM / One hub + direct access
GAIN / Easy gathering; simple care

NOT ADOPTED / Food and seasonal learning lack distinct spaces; gathering lacks a close connection to Blackwood.

B / WOODLAND CIRCUIT

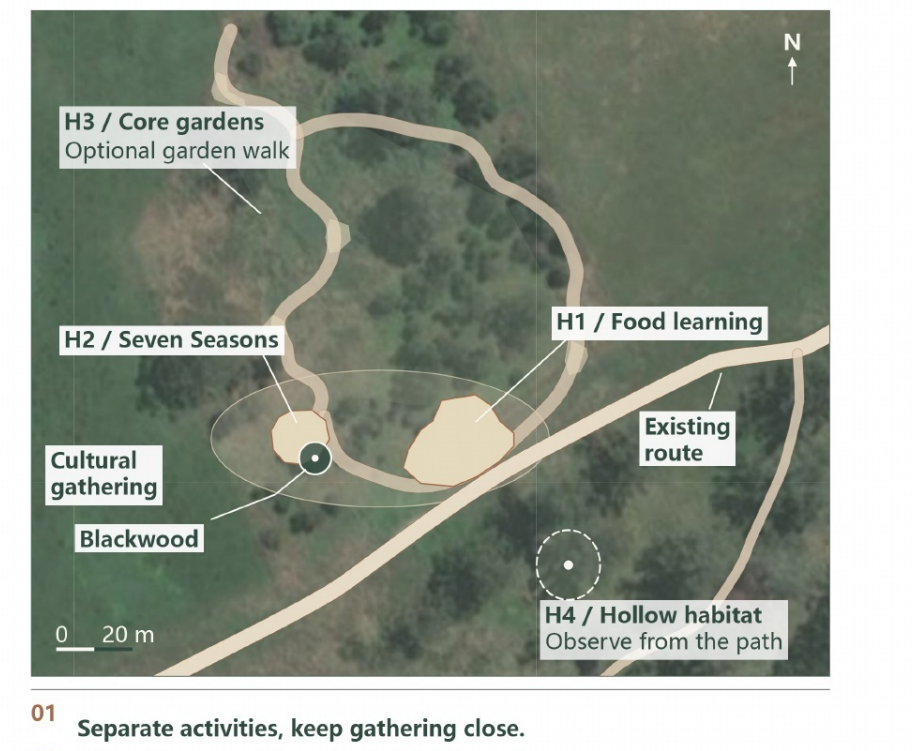


FORM / Four rooms + a loop
GAIN / Varied encounters; distinct uses

NOT ADOPTED / Learning is spread along a longer loop; short group visits and maintenance are harder to organise.

02.5 / Final spatial strategy

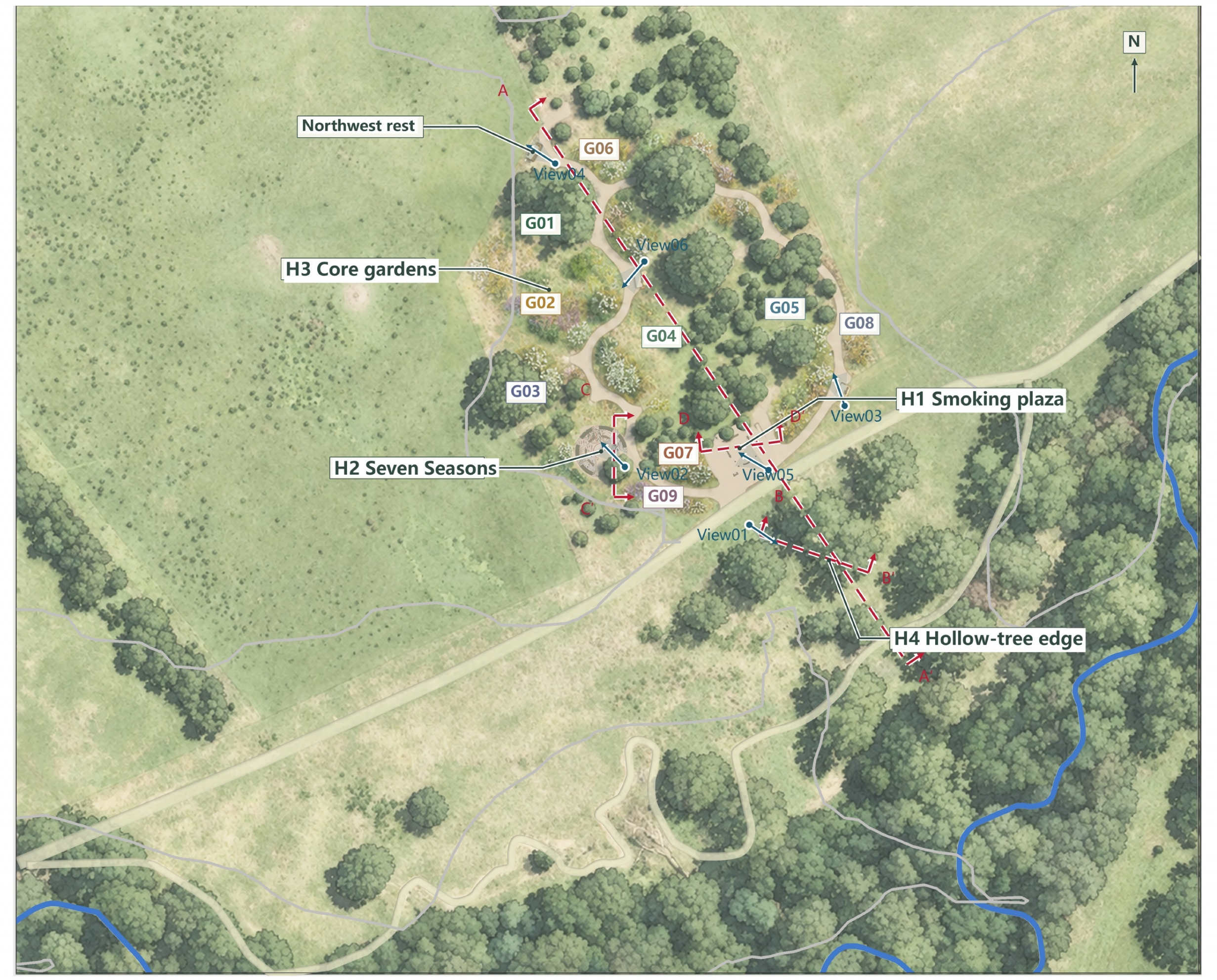
Distinct learning spaces, one cultural core



01 Separate activities, keep gathering close.
02 Connect seasonal learning to Blackwood.
03 Follow the complete loop for varied experiences.

03 / Cultural gathering in the woodland

03.1 / Core plan



View04

View03

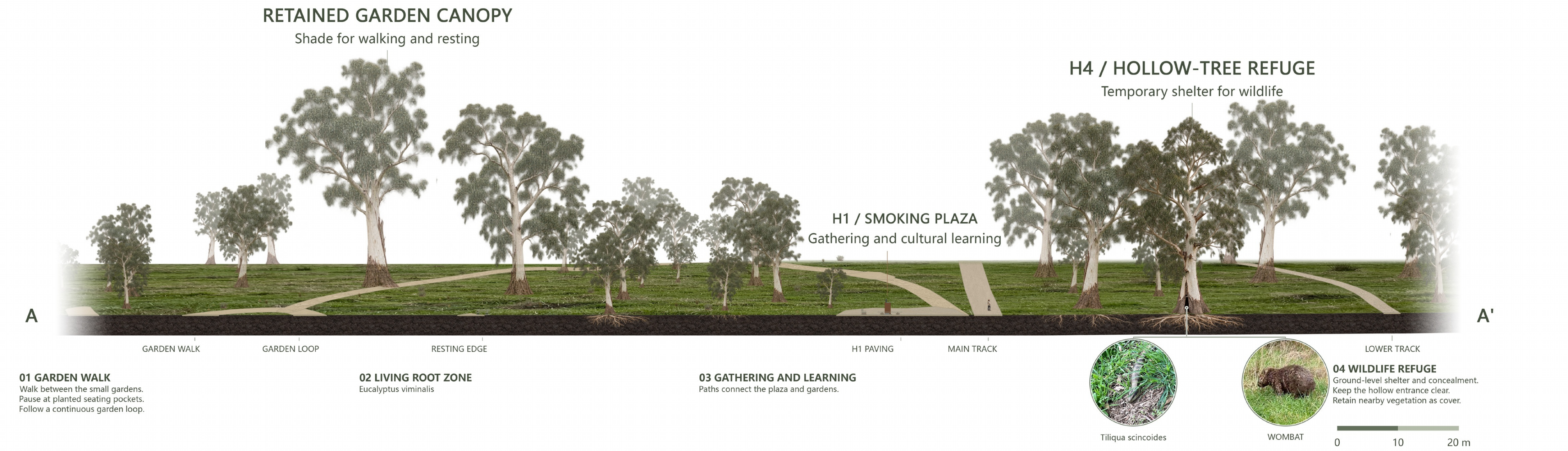
View02

View01

SECTION INDEX
03.2 / A–A' Landscape section
03.4 / D–D' Eel smoking and cultural learning
03.3 / C–C' Seven Seasons gathering place
03.5 / B–B' Retain the hollow as habitat

03.2 / A–A' Landscape section

NW TO SE / LOOKING NE



01 GARDEN WALK
Walk between the small gardens.
Pause at planted seating pockets.
Follow a continuous garden loop.

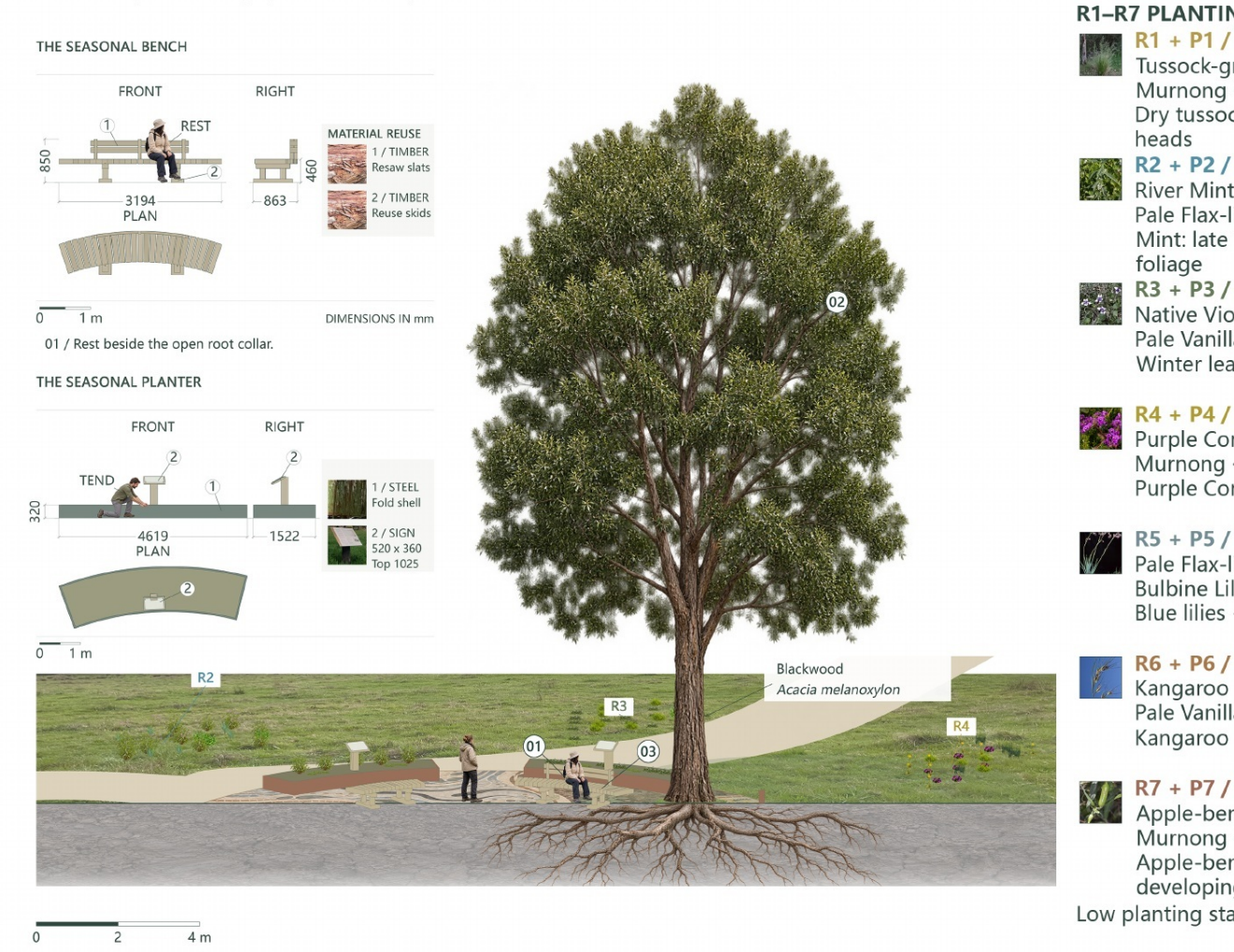
02 LIVING ROOT ZONE
Eucalyptus viminalis

03 GATHERING AND LEARNING
Paths connect the plaza and gardens.

04 WILDLIFE REFUGE
Ground-level shelter and concealment.
Keep the hollow entrance clear.
Retain nearby vegetation as cover.

03.3 / C–C' Seven Seasons gathering place

Follow the planted ring; gather in the open centre.

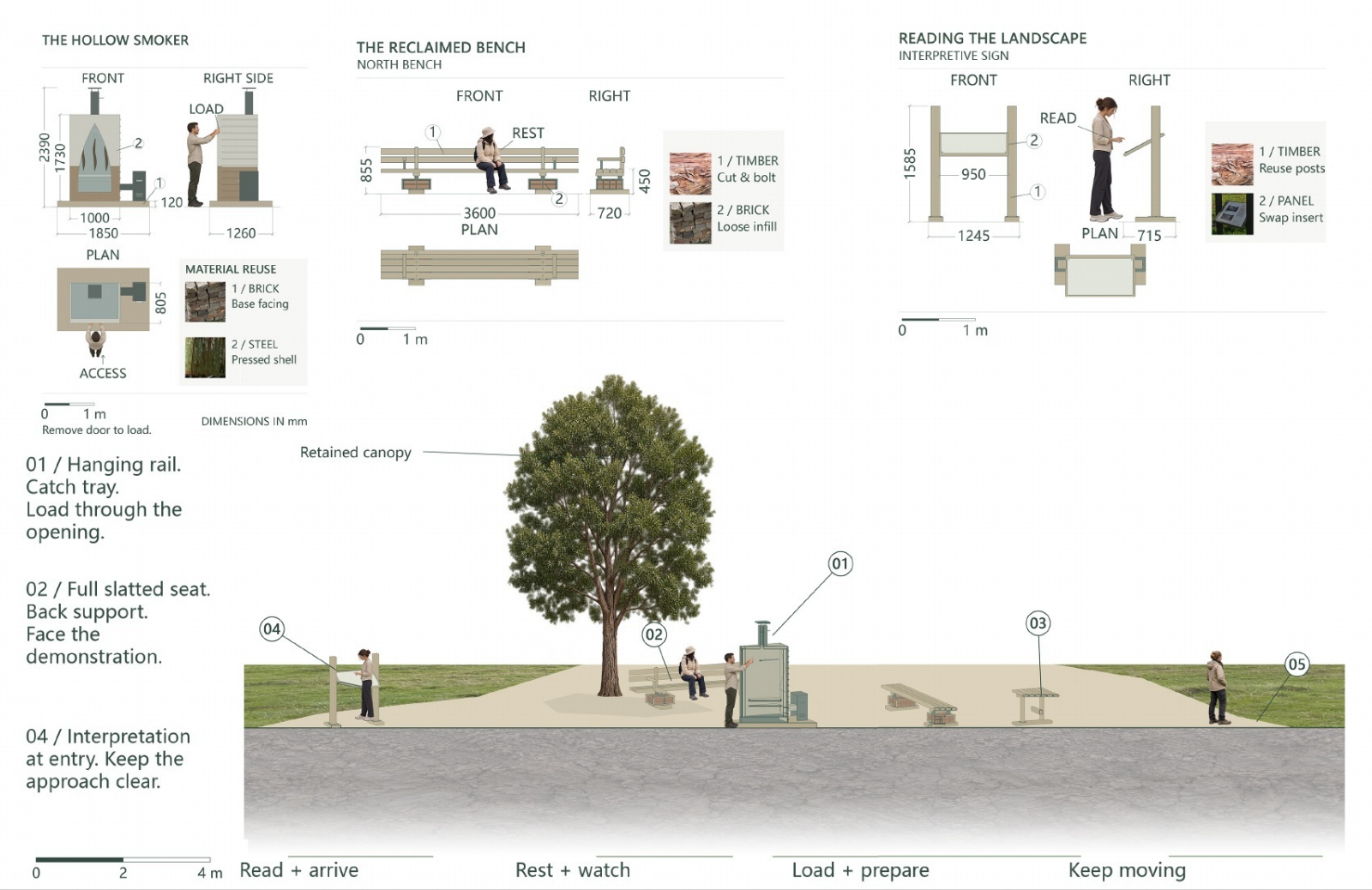


R1–R7 PLANTING / P1–P7 PAVING

- **R1 + P1 / BIDERAP / JAN–FEB** Tussock-grass · Kangaroo Grass Murnong · Weeping Grass Dry tussocks + retained seed heads
- **R2 + P2 / LUK / MAR** River Mint · Pale Vanilla-lily Pale Flax-lily · Kidney-weed Mint: late flowers + aromatic foliage
- **R3 + P3 / WARING / APR–JUL** Native Violet · Weeping Grass Pale Vanilla-lily · Apple-berry Winter leaf cover + low violet mat
- **R4 + P4 / GULING / AUG** Purple Coral-pea · Bulbine Lily Murnong · Weeping Grass Purple Coral-pea in flower
- **R5 + P5 / POORNEET / SEP–OCT** Pale Flax-lily · Murnong Bulbine Lily · Weeping Grass Blue lilies + yellow herb flowers
- **R6 + P6 / BUATH GURRU / NOV** Kangaroo Grass · Murnong Pale Vanilla-lily · Weeping Grass Kangaroo Grass flower heads
- **R7 + P7 / GUNYANG / DEC** Apple-berry · Native Raspberry Murnong · Weeping Grass Apple-berry: flowers to developing fruit

Low planting stays behind the seat.

03.4 / D–D' Eel smoking and cultural learning

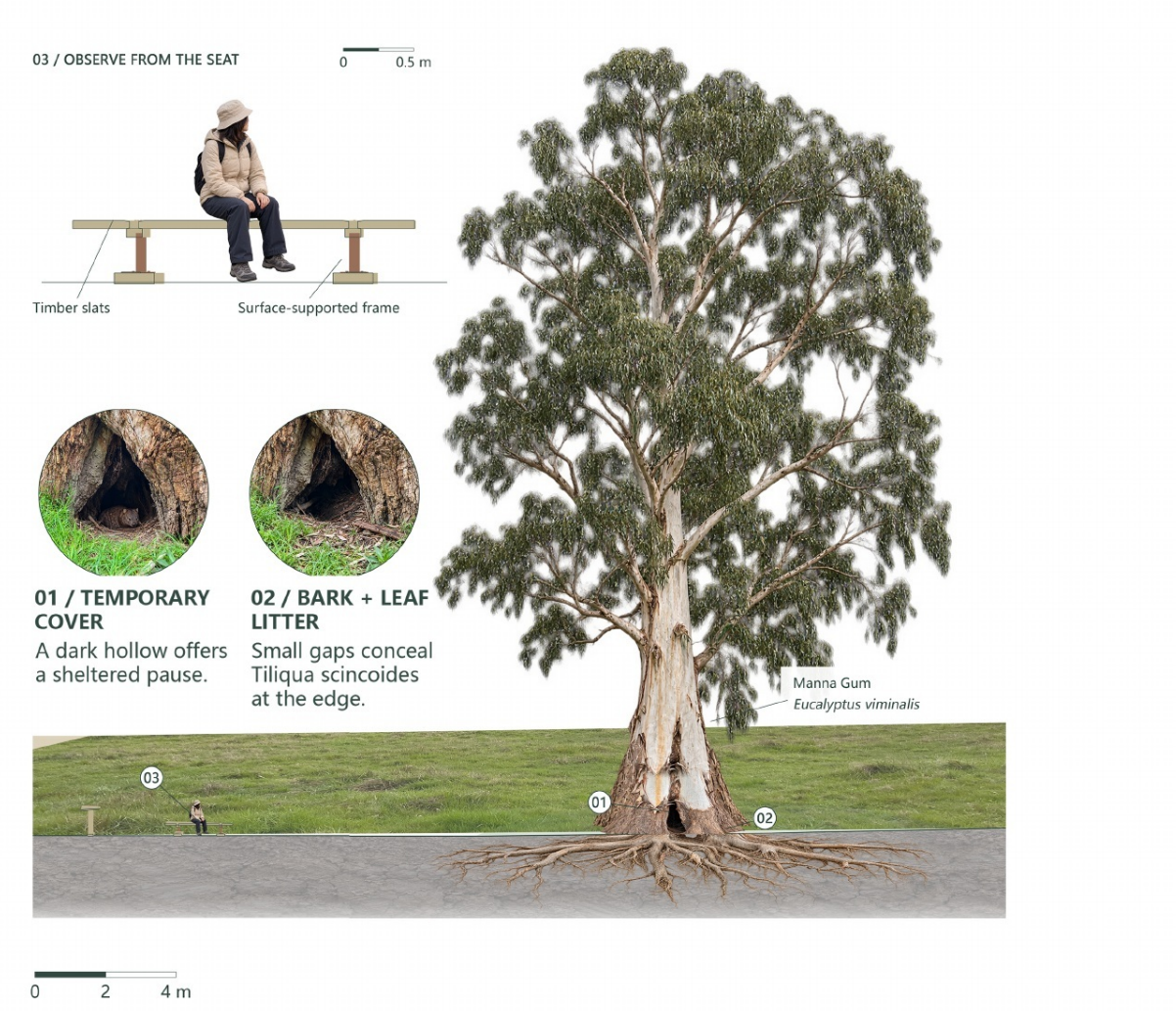


01 / Hanging rail. Catch tray. Load through the opening.

02 / Full slatted seat. Back support. Face the demonstration.

04 / Interpretation at entry. Keep the approach clear.

03.5 / B–B' Retain the hollow as habitat



01 / TEMPORARY COVER
A dark hollow offers a sheltered pause.

02 / BARK + LEAF LITTER
Small gaps conceal Tiliqua scincoides at the edge.

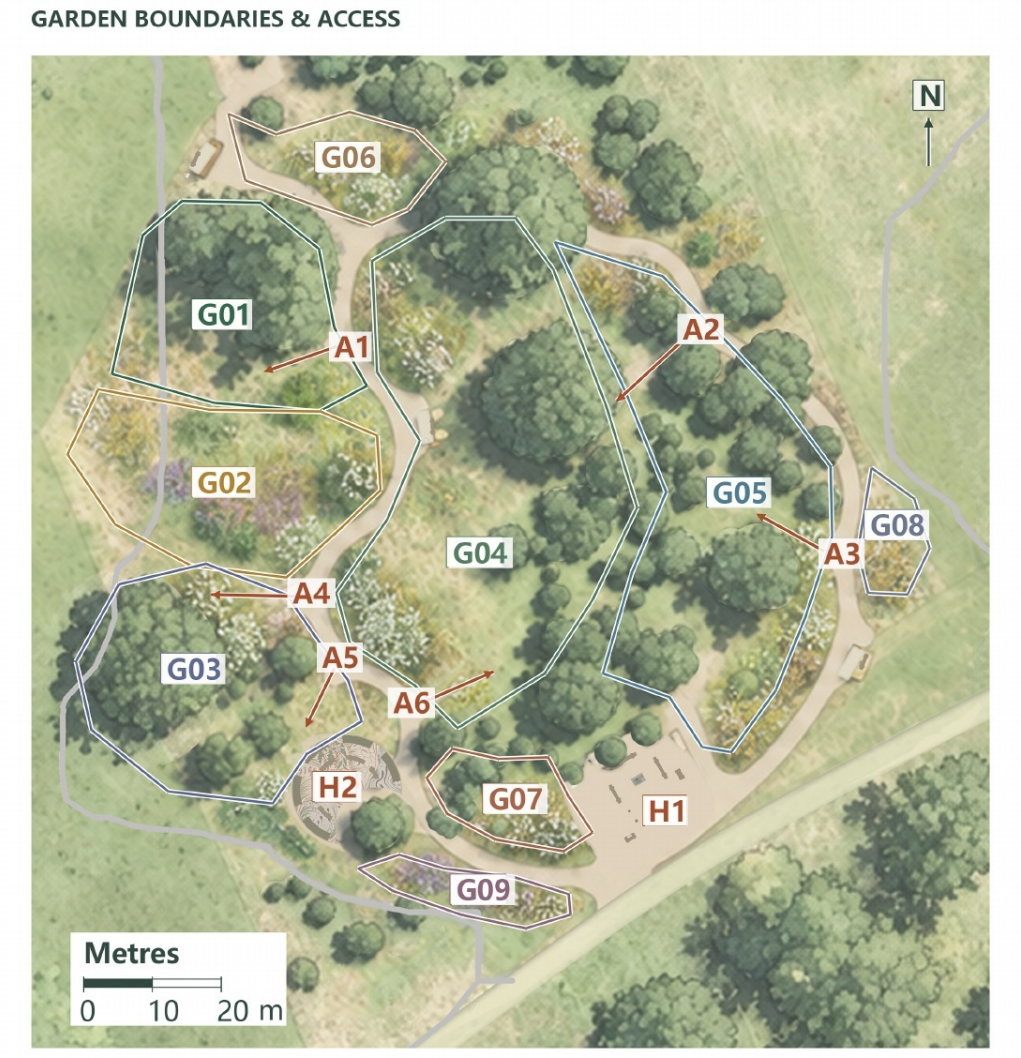
03.6 / View06 Core gardens

03.7 / View05 Food, stories and gathering

04 / Learn with the seasons

04.1 / Planting: make seasonal change visible

GARDEN BOUNDARIES & ACCESS



GARDEN MIXES

G01 Woodland rest
MS 30% + MW 25% + AM 20% + BM 10% + DL 15%
Low grass edge, flowering herbs and low fruit supports.
A1: enter from the north-west walk.

G02 Edible meadow
MW 35% + BB 20% + TT 25% + MS 20%
Murnong and Bulbine in small groups; grasses behind.
A1 / A4: retain the west-side opening.

G03 Woodland edge
MS 35% + VH 20% + BM 20% + CQ 10% + AM 15%
Low groundcover, low fruit supports and rear shrubs.
A4 / A5: keep both path entries open.

G04 Central understory
MS 40% + AM 20% + MW 20% + PE 20%
Flowering herbs in light gaps; taller grasses behind.
A2 / A6: connect the woodland clearings.

G05 Eastern woodland
BM 20% + RP 20% + CQ 10% + MA 10% + MS 25% + DL 15%
Separate fruit supports and contained moist pockets.
A3: connect to the central understory.

G06 North pocket
MW 30% + BB 25% + PL 20% + MS 25%
Low yellow-flowering herbs with grasses behind.
View from the existing rest-path end.

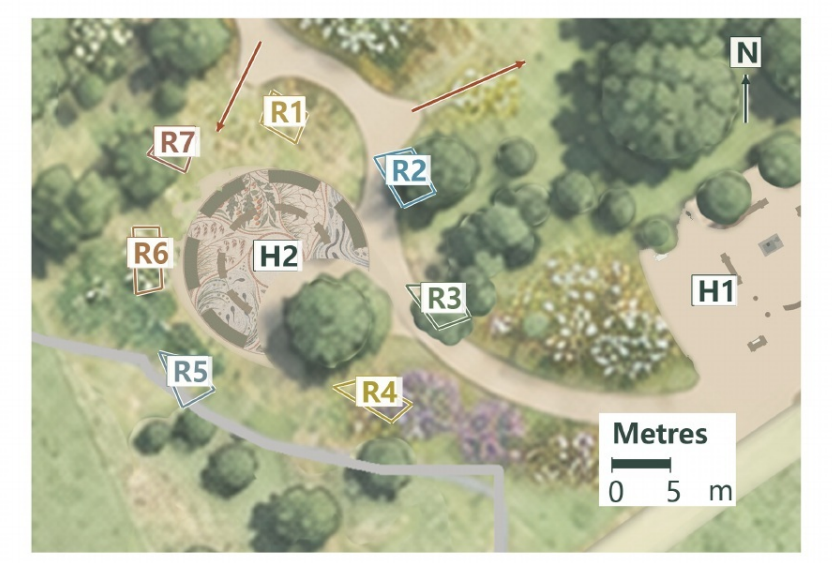
G07 Food garden
MA 25% + MW 25% + BB 20% + BM 10% + DR 20%
Accessible food herbs with contained moist planting.
Enter from H1; keep the work area clear.

G08 Outer-edge flowers
TT 30% + PL 20% + BB 25% + DL 25%
Low flowers by the path; taller grasses farther back.
View from the existing eastern walk.

G09 Arrival planting
MW 30% + BB 25% + HV 20% + MS 25%
Low purple and yellow flowers with continuous grass.
Keep the main-path junction open.

A1-A6 / KEEP ENTRIES OPEN
Target a clear width of 1.5-1.8 m between mature plants. Keep foliage low around openings;
set prickly branches back. Maintain the east approach to H2.

H2 / SEVEN SEASONS CONTEXT



R1-R7 / GROUND MIXES

R1 Biderap North / dry season	PL 40% + TT 25% + MW 20% + MS 15%
R2 Luk North-east / eel season	MA 35% + AM 20% + DL 15% + DR 30%
R3 Waring South-east / wet season	VH 45% + MS 30% + AM 15% + BM 10%
R4 Guling South / orchid season	HV 35% + BB 25% + MW 20% + MS 20%
R5 Poorneet South-west / tadpole season	DL 30% + MW 35% + BB 15% + MS 20%
R6 Buath Gurru West / grass-flower season	TT 40% + MW 30% + AM 15% + MS 15%
R7 Gunyang North-west / fruit season	BM 30% + RP 20% + MW 20% + MS 30%

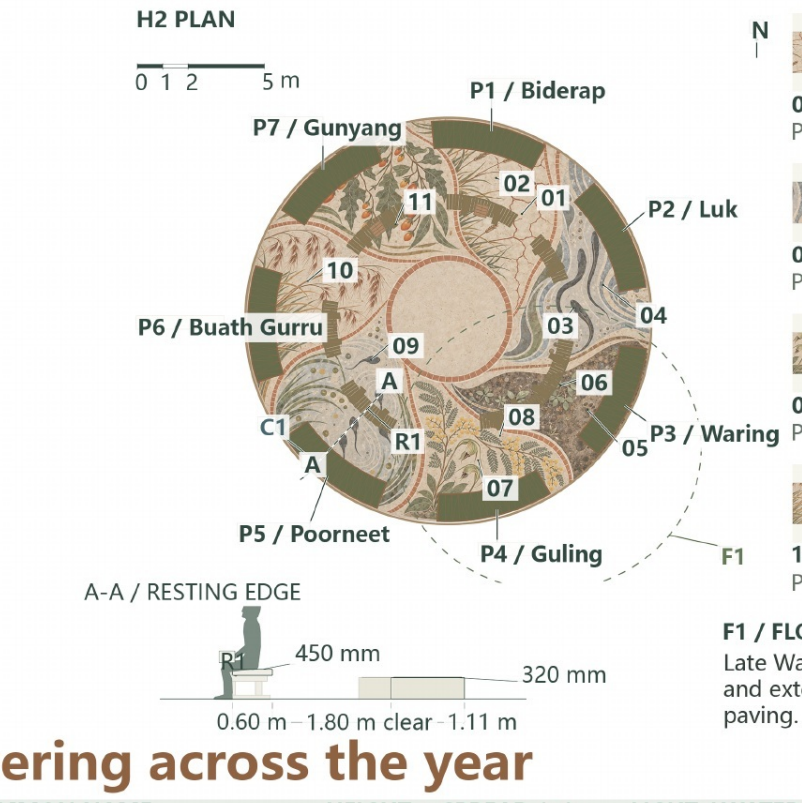
P1-P7 / PLANTERS

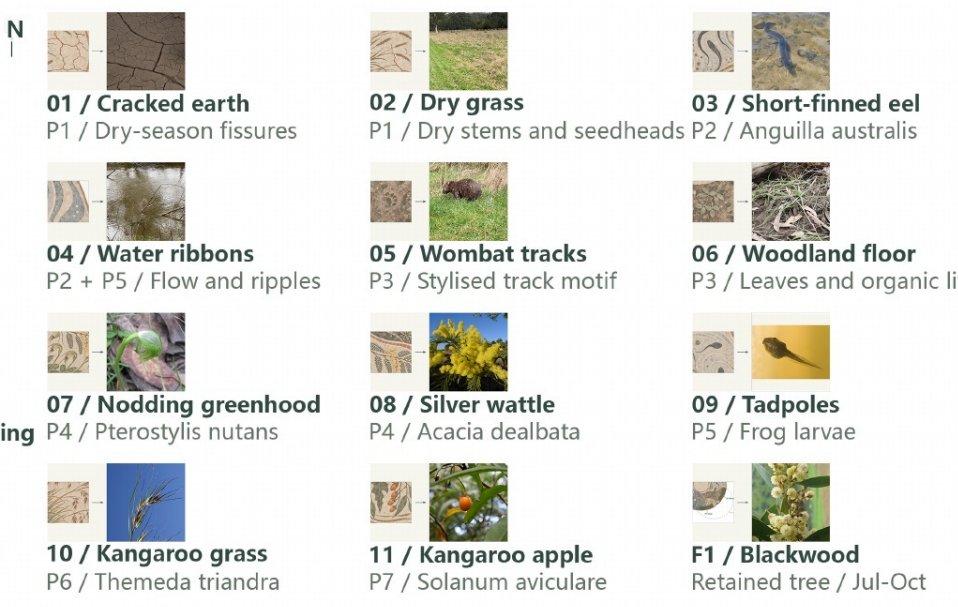
P1 PS 8 + MW 4
P2 MA 5 + DR 6
P3 VH 12 + DR 4
P4 HV 2 + PS 3
P5 DL 6 + MW 8
P6 TT 5 + MW 6
P7 BM 2 + DR 8

Boundaries mark management areas; retain open paths.
Percentages refer to net planted area.
R pockets overlay G areas; count overlap once.

04.2 / Seven Seasons paving patterns

H2 PLAN





F1 / FLOWERING AT THE GULING EDGE
Late Waring Southeast crown / beside the Waring-Guling transition. Flowering overlaps Guling and extends into adjoining seasons. Blackwood differs from the Silver Wattle depicted in the paving.

04.3 / Flowering across the year

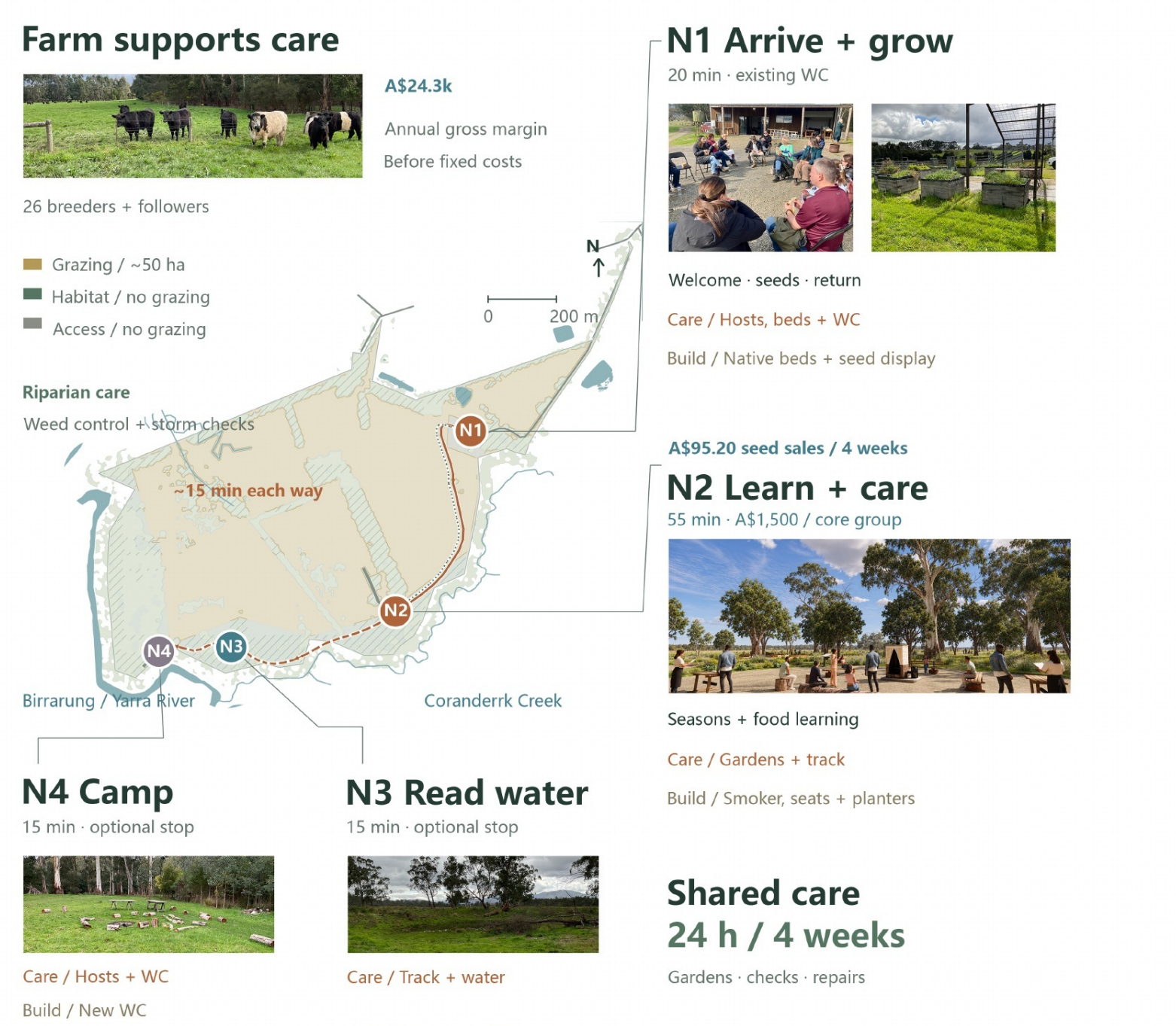
■ Main □ Occasional

CODE	BOTANICAL / COMMON NAME	HEIGHT × SPREAD (m)	LIGHT / WATER	LOCATION	Ja	Fe	Mr	Ap	My	Jn	Jl	Au	Se	Oc	No	De
FOOD-THEME HERBS, CLIMBERS & SHRUBS																
MW	Microseris walteri Murnong	0.15–0.50 × 0.15–0.25	Sun / part shade Well drained	G01/02/04/06/07/09; R1/4/5/6/7; P1/5/6	■	■	■						■	■	■	■
MA	Mentha australis River Mint	0.20–0.80 × 0.30–1.00	Sun / part shade Moist; contain roots	G05/07; R2; P2	■	■	■						■	■	■	■
BM	Billardiera mutabilis Common Apple-berry	Low frame: 0.8–1.2 H	Sun / part shade Dry–moist; drained	G01/03/05/07; R3/7; P7	■					■	■	■	■	■	■	■
RP	Rubus parvifolius Native Raspberry	0.60–1.00 × 0.50–2.00	Sun / part shade Moist; well drained	G05 rear edge; R7 extension										■	■	■
CQ	Coprosma quadrifida Prickly Currant-bush	2.00–4.00 × 1.00–1.50	Part shade Moist; well drained	G03/05 broad rear edges									■	■	■	■
AM	Arthropodium milleflorum Pale Vanilla-lily	Stems 0.7–1.3; W ~0.4	Sun / part shade Well drained	G01/03/04; R2/3/6	■	■									■	■
BB	Bulbine bulbosa Bulbine Lily	0.20–0.50 × 0.30	Sun / part shade Well drained	G02/06/07/08/09; R4/5	■								■	■	■	■
GRASSES, LILIES & GROUNDCOVERS																
TT	Themeda triandra Kangaroo Grass	Foliage ~0.4 × 0.75	Sun / part shade Well drained	G02/08; R1/6; P6	■	■							■	■	■	■
PL	Poa labillardierei Common Tussock-grass	0.30–1.00 × 0.30–0.70	Sun / part shade Moist; well drained	G06/08 rear; R1 broad areas	■	■								■	■	■
PE	Poa ensiformis Purple-sheathed Tussock-grass	Leaves 0.3–0.75 H	Part shade Moist; well drained	G04 rear layer	■	■	■							■	■	■
MS	Microlaena stipoides Weeping Grass	Foliage ~0.3 × 0.6	Part shade / sun Drained; shade tolerant	G01–06/09; R1/3–7	■	■	■	□	□	□	□	□	□	■	■	■
DL	Dianella longifolia var. longifolia Pale Flax-lily	0.30–0.80 × ~0.50	Sun / part shade Well drained	G01/05/08; R2/5; P5	■							■	■	■	■	■
DR	Dichondra repens Kidney-weed	~0.05–0.10 H; mat	Part / full shade Moist–dry; drained	G07; R2; P2/3/7									■	■	■	■
VH	Viola hederacea Native Violet	To 0.17 H × 1–2 W	Part / full shade Moist; well drained	G03; R3; P3	■	■	■	□	□	■	■	■	■	■	■	■
HV	Hardenbergia violacea Purple Coral-pea	Stems to ~2.0 long	Sun / part shade Well drained	G09; R4; P4							■	■	■	■	■	
PS	Poa sieberiana var. sieberiana Grey Tussock-grass	Foliage 0.15–0.30 × 0.40	Sun / part shade Well drained	P1/4; narrow R1 option	■	■	■							■	■	■
CONDITIONAL SELECTIONS																
JP	Juncus procerus Tall Rush	1.00–2.50 × 0.60–1.50	Part / dappled shade Wet soil only	G05 wet rear pocket only										■	■	■
PN	Pterostylis nutans Nodding Greenhood	0.10–0.30 H	Part / full shade Specialist care	P4 / R4 seasonal display			■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■		
PC	Prostanthera lasianthos Coranderrk Bush	2.00–10.00 × 2.00–5.00	Part shade / sun Moist; well drained	R6 broad outer extension only	■										■	■
SA	Solanum aviculare Kangaroo Apple	1.00–3.00 × 1.00–4.00	Sun / part shade Well drained	R7 broad outer sample only	■	■							■	■	■	■

04.4 / H2 Three seasonal views

05 / Support ongoing care

8 visitors · 2 hosts · Core visit ~1 h 45 min



Farm supports care
A$24.3k
Annual gross margin
Before fixed costs
26 breeders + followers

- Grazing / ~50 ha
- Habitat / no grazing
- Access / no grazing

Riparian care
Weed control + storm checks

N1 Arrive + grow
20 min · existing WC
Welcome · seeds · return
Care / Hosts, beds + WC
Build / Native beds + seed display

A$95.20 seed sales / 4 weeks

N2 Learn + care
55 min · A$1,500 / core group
Seasons + food learning
Care / Gardens + track
Build / Smoker, seats + planters

N4 Camp
15 min · optional stop
Care / Hosts + WC
Build / New WC

N3 Read water
15 min · optional stop
Care / Track + water
Build / No new build

Shared care
24 h / 4 weeks
Gardens · checks · repairs

Full route ~2 h 50 min • A$2,000 / group

4-WEEK CORE PILOT / ESTIMATED

Income	Running costs	Balance
A$6,095.20	A$3,715.50	A$2,379.70
4 core groups + seeds	Hosts, care + other costs	Before tax / overheads; build + extensions excluded.

Care: visits + seeds + cleared farm surplus | Build: capital funds